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Movie Tourism—A New Form of Cultural Landscape?

Bronwyn Jewell
Susan McKinnon

ABSTRACT. Tourism originally was perceived as visitors travelling, whether within their own country or internationally, for pleasure. However, over the years, tourism has evolved into different components and labels. One is Movie Tourism. Although people have travelled due to novels they have read or historical occurrences, it would appear that movies based on these aspects have increased visitation. It would seem that Movie Tourism could be a new form of cultural landscape. Over time the appeal of destinations has grown and altered from the preconception that movies portray to audiences. It could further be perceived that Movie Tourism is connected to nostalgia and identity. A yearning for what life was or should be like, creating identities within historical settings, imaginary and/or factual. This paper is a discourse on the aforementioned and the tourist dollar value that Movie Tourism contributes to a country's economy.

KEYWORDS. Movies, tourism, cultural landscapes, place-identity

INTRODUCTION

Movie Tourism can be seen as a new form of cultural landscape. Cultural landscapes are the interaction between and evolution of a society's internal and external social, economic and cultural aspects, influenced by the natural environment's physical constraints and/or opportunities (United Nations Educational, Scientific & Cultural Organisation (UNESCO), 1997). It can thus be compared and perceived that Movie Tourism is an opportunity to influence individuals and society as a whole to visit destinations. According to UNESCO (1997), cultural landscapes are divided into three

categories. Firstly, the clearly defined landscape, which is designed and created intentionally for aesthetic reasons and often associated with religious and/or monumental buildings; secondly, the organically evolved landscape which is created initially for economic, social, religious, or administrative purposes and changes over time to reflect changes in form and function. The third category, the associative cultural landscape, is because of religious, cultural or artistic associations with the natural environment rather than any significant or present material culture.

In comparing Movie Tourism to the aforementioned UNESCO (1997) categories,

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aspects such as a film's location, the associated scenery, buildings, and story can influence the cultural landscape of a country. *The Da Vinci Code* (Brown, 2003) being one such recent movie could be contrasted and compared to the above categories. Set in France and England, the premise of the story is that Jesus Christ rather than having been crucified, lived and married Mary Magdalene and procreated (Brown, 2003). To stop this truth from being discovered, a monk from Opus Dei (Brown, 2003), an organisation founded exclusively for men by Josemaría Escrivá de Balaguer as a Christian lay association (De Los Reyes & Rich, 2005) assassinates in order to keep the Catholic Church in power. Regarding *The Da Vinci Code* (Brown, 2003), the story and now the film, has all three categories of cultural landscapes—clearly defined as it is associated with both religious—The Vatican, and a monumental building—The Louvre. The organically evolved landscape, created for economic gain and religious conspiracy theories, creating also changes in form and function of a country's tourism destination image. The associative cultural landscape—religious, cultural or artistic associations with the natural environment rather than any significant or present material culture, is true of *The Da Vinci Code* (Brown, 2003). Although classified as a work of fiction, there is indication of a large number of people believing the theory of Jesus Christ procreating with Mary Magdalene (Petre, 2006).

FROM PAPER TO CELLULOID TO PLACE-IDENTITY

It would seem that successful films which in turn motivate and attract tourists to the films' location settings, were originally in novel form. As noted by Herbert (2001), literary places are no longer the sites of a writer's birthplace or death, nor of historical fact. Rather these places are social constructions, created and in turn, promoted to attract tourists. A film based on a novel

can raise awareness to the public of a country or more specifically a city or town. It has been stated that literary places are part of the cultural landscape of heritage tourism (Squire, 1996; Herbert, 2001). Published in 1908, *Anne of Green Gables'* village of Avonlea is fictionally based on the village of Cavendish, Prince Edward Island, Canada. Although there are incorporations of actual sites from the village of Cavendish, the novel depicts and reflects an imagined geography and overtones (Squire, 1996). The writer, Lucy Maud Montgomery died in 1943, yet, had already noted earlier that the international success of the novels based on the lead character had created overt tourist interest (Squire, 1996). This was before any of the novels were transferred onto celluloid.

The Lord of the Rings trilogy is another set of fictional writing. Although based on an imaginary Middle Earth and not a real place, the movie versions have created a specific movie induced tourism industry for New Zealand (Heath, 2005). Due to the high number of tourists visiting New Zealand to view the scenery as portrayed in the trilogy, tours have now been created specifically to cater for the 150+ locations utilised. Herbert (2001) suggests that visitors are more concerned with aspects that raise interest and arouse imagination, rather than the distinction between fiction and reality. In assessment of Herbert's (2001) discourse, Middle Earth is an imaginary world, yet it has created meaning and emotions that are real to audiences globally. The trilogy has created excitement, interest and involvement; the landscape of New Zealand can be related to Middle Earth and to people's internal narratives as purported by Herbert (2001). Thus the comparison to associative cultural landscape as defined by UNESCO (1997) can be made; so too can the Australian movie, *The Man From Snowy River* and its sequel.

Based on the poem of the same name written by A.B. "Banjo" Patterson, and published as *The Man from Snowy River and Other Verses* in 1895, it is believed the book of ballads sold 10,000 copies in its first

year (Images Australia, 2006). The popularity of the poem and of Banjo Patterson's other works has resulted in republication throughout the 20th Century since his death in 1941 (Paterson, 1983). The first movie was released in 1982 with the sequel in 1988 (Australian Film Commission, 2005). Australia's High Country in Victoria, the poem's setting, has witnessed an increase in horseback tourism, restaurants and saddlery suppliers in the location where the movies were filmed (Beeton, 2001a). Before the release of the first film, two horseback tour operators existed (Beeton, 2001b). In 1993 there were over 27 (Beeton, 2001b) and in 1996 there were more than 30 (Beeton, 2001a).

The novel *Bridges of Madison County*, based on a fictional love affair in a small American town, has also been transferred to celluloid (Jinhua & Chen, 1997). As noted by Jinhua and Chen (1997), the novel is set during a revolutionary period of American history, the 1960s, and portrays what people imagine true love to be. This portrayal of imaginary true love romanticises a period of change and as such, alters remembrance of memories to one of nostalgia (Jinhua & Chen, 1997). Novels attract visitors to destinations and their clearly defined cultural landscapes, with the movie versions raising further awareness to a global audience that may not have read the novels. Furthermore, these cultural landscapes undergo changes and are continually evolving due to these novels, subsequent movie, and consequent tourism impacts. Changes can be physical or within an individual's or societies' values, perception and association (Jones, 1993; Lowenthal, 1993; Pearson & Sullivan, 1995; Serageldin, 1999).

It could also be argued that Movie Tourism is based on a form of imagined nostalgia. Nostalgia symbolises an idyllic bygone era. A romantic ideology or yearning to return to what the world should still be (Jones, 1993; Lowenthal, 1993, 1996; Goulding, 2001; Graburn, 2001; McKercher & du Cros, 2002). It does not necessarily have to be nostalgia for previous lived experiences;

it can also be identification with places, people, or other aspects that have been experienced via movies, books, and other narratives (Beck, 1995; Lowenthal, 1996; Goulding, 2001; Herbert, 2001). It should be noted that although this concept of nostalgia, and thus Movie Tourism, may offer visitors an insight into the past, it is also sterilised. Disease, poverty, smell, exploitation of workers, and poor living conditions of the lower class in society is not shown (Jones, 1993; Lowenthal, 1996; Goulding, 2001).

The authenticity of a movie deals with a combination of facts, imagination and myths; not necessarily scientific historical evidence, rather an experience and a new reality based on tangible remains (Herbert, 2001; Jewell & Crofts, 2001; Frost, 2004) which are the movies' locations. Myths can be more powerful in terms of guiding action rather than the truth. It could be said that individuals and groups have manipulated the past, misconstruing the past for their own purposes. The more superficial the view of the past, the easier it is for others to impose and transpose misconceptions upon the present (Vaughn, 1985; Lowenthal, 1996). Thus it is easier for films based on fictional places and characters to engage the audience into believing the story is one of truth, or of reminiscing nostalgically of a romanticised past (Jinhua & Chen, 1997; Frost, 2004); representation aimed at consumerism (Jinhua & Chen, 1997); or, as in the case of *The Man From Snowy River* movies, representing the imagined perceptions of Australia and Australian values to a potential tourist market (Beeton, 2001b). In turn, this can create a desire to visit the locations of a movie's setting in order to become part of this cultural landscape, an organically evolved landscape created for economic purposes.

As with any landscape, what one group of people may perceive as natural, may well be cultural to another (Jones, 1993). Usually, natural landscape is generally conceived to be areas that do not have cities developed within their boundaries, an idealised differentiation and contrast between town and

country (Jones, 1993). Nature is a place for leisure activities, seen and experienced as aesthetically pleasing and romantic (Jones, 1993; Kelly, 1998) and it could be argued that landscapes portrayed within movies further substantiate and reinforce this notion. It could then be further argued that natural landscapes are a subset of cultural landscapes due to the reasoning that the notion of 'cultural landscapes' are a social construct and embodied in cultural experiences (Kelly, 1998). According to Aplin (1998), researchers have argued that humans have maintained a genetic connection or need for closeness to nature, allowing them to de-stress from their modern life. This intrinsic value of wanting to be close to nature can manifest in many forms—going to the beach or national park, camping with the family, or as part of a tourism package such as the ones offered by New Zealand and its Middle Earth landscape. Natural landscapes provide a connection and sense of place (Beck, 1995) and the success of movies and their affects on tourism destinations strengthens this. Cultural landscapes embody the various layers of human interaction over time—a palimpsest of history, and it can be purported that movie destinations become part of this.

Globally, society creates material remains. This can be in the form of buildings, documents, ceremonies, technological changes, poems, or paintings (Hall & Bowen, 1989; Orser, 1996) and in the case of the movie industry—movies and their subsequent affect of Movie Tourism upon the cultural landscape. Movie Tourism can provide for an individual a connection in the scheme of life; and for a movie-going global community, an attachment to a destination. This destination, as with the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy, may not necessarily be 'real' but to the individual or community, the actual location is real and therefore allows imagination influenced by the movie's trilogy to complete the missing pieces. In some cases, the destination is as real as a movie's portrayal. The *Star Wars* movies are one such example. Visitors can travel to Tunisia and

see Tataouine, an actual city, yet portrayed in the movie as Luke Skywalker's home planet. Visitors can even stay in Luke Skywalker's physical home which is in reality a hotel (Jeffery, 2004) and can have drinks in the room where Luke and his Uncle and Aunt ate their meals. Perhaps these new cultural landscapes, created by movies and the subsequent movie tourism industry, can be in part a new form of identity among the global movie public.

Identity is a shared pattern of meanings with others, creating for the individual security and solidarity in the form of community, and in turn, conceptual and physical boundaries in which to operate. Identity is a cognitive access to the world, providing a framework regarding perspective and understanding (Poole, 1999; Schöpflin, 2000). It is not a passive acquisition but rather a process of self-formation which is socially available in acquiring social identity (Poole, 1999). Mazlish's (1993) view is that the concept of identity is a Western-derived notion and the connection that links people is primordial. That is, the links are unthinking and basic, organic in terms of kinship, blood and land. Whether constructed or inherent, a person's sense of identity is frequently connected to land (Mazlish, 1993; Clayton & Opatow, 2003) and it is the locations of popular movies that influence people.

The need to belong to a collective group is part of the human psyche (Lerner, 1985). It can be proposed that this new form of identity, created by the new cultural landscapes from the movie industry, is a part of place-identity. Place-identity is a construct of feelings, memories, conceptions, interpretations and ideas about a particular physical setting as well as a type of setting, providing a function for identity (Dixon & Durrheim, 2000; Holmes, 2003). Movies and their affects upon tourism destinations can be compared to this concept of place-identity. Those who travel specifically to a movie's location setting can be seen as searching for a psychological need or connection to belong to the movie's plotline of adventure,

romance, fantasy, or conspiracy theory. Further to this, place-identity has also been defined as humans' attempt to control their environment.

This attempt to control the environment has created and sustained a coherent sense of self, a sense of belonging which is a necessary basis for place-identity. It is the interaction and usage of the natural and built environment, suggesting that the environment is not simply a setting but rather it is actively incorporated into sense of self and identity (Dixon & Durrheim, 2000; Holmes, 2003; Dixon & Durrheim, 2004). Perhaps this then explains those who are passionate about movies such as *Star Wars*, *Harry Potter*, and *Star Trek* where individuals dress as their favourite characters and collectively attend movies, meetings, exhibitions, and conventions to exchange information, memorabilia, and forge new or strengthen existing friendships. Languages, such as Klingon, have developed specifically due to movies, creating again another layer of self-identity and belonging to a community and cultural landscape. Religious and spiritual beliefs have also been influenced with over 70,000 people in the Australian 2001 census claiming their religion as Jedi Knights from the *Star Wars* movie series (Mathewson, Walker, Bailey & Ehler, 2006). 2006 Australian Census results are yet to be released but it will be interesting to see how many Jedi Knights now live in Australia.

FROM REEL TO REAL—THE SET JETTERS

In discussing movies as a new form of cultural landscapes, a short digress of the dollar value of movies to the tourism industry must also be reviewed. The term "Hollywood" conjures images of glamour, movie stars, exotic movie sets and locations and has been known as the 'place' where movies are made. However, according to Leigh (2005) the only major studio left in Hollywood is Paramount. Even the home to the major movie theme park, Universal, has moved from the region. Behind

this curious state of affairs is the explanation that more movies are made outside Hollywood than in the City of Los Angeles itself (Leigh, 2005). Locations in Australia can be disguised as deserts in Morocco; Canada can easily double for quaint English countryside; and New Zealand, the setting for a turn of the century Japanese Samurai training ground, *The Last Samurai*.

Digitally un-enhanced breathtaking natural scenery appear across theatre screens for a few hours, prompting emotional responses of the 'must see holiday destination' as movies have, according to Riley and van Doren (1992), become pull factors enhanced by viewer involvement in the story. Thompson Holidays in the United Kingdom (Jones, 2002) estimate that 80% of Britons plan their holidays specifically after viewing a movie, thus creating a new class of tourist, the 'set jetter' (Linge, 2006, Richardson, 2006). Popular movie locations include New Zealand—*Lord of the Rings* trilogy; the Greek Island of Cephalonia—*Captain Corelli's Mandolin*; Thailand—*The Beach*; Malta—*Troy*; Kenya—*Out of Africa* (Jones, 2002); Newfoundland—*The Shipping News*; England—*The Harry Potter series*; and Montmartre, Paris—*Amelie* and *Moulin Rouge* (Rodriguez, 2002).

Morgan and Pritchard (1998) consider that placing a known destination in a movie can be construed as the ultimate in tourism product placement as these locations are shown in a favourable light. This Movie Tourism niche has an appeal to everyone with its diversified marketplace. It offers the chance to walk the *Bridges of Madison County*, visit the birthplace in Tunisia of Luke Skywalker, follow the hobbits journey to Middle Earth and be swept up in the intrigue of *The Da Vinci Code* conspiracy from the Vatican to Paris to England. One of the most positive benefits that has arisen is the exposure of movie locations and their attractions and attributes on the worldwide movie going public which, in turn, can influence travel and destination choice decision making processes. This makes these movie locations an extraordinary force in

destination marketing and the success of a movie can ensure tourism increases over a four to five year period of 50% (Anon, 2006). This can be seen with two of the most popular movie franchises in movie history. The top ten highest grossing movies of all time (Table 1) include all three *Lord of the Rings* movies and three of the four *Harry Potter* movies (adapted from The Numbers, 2006, p. 1).

The number of movie-going patrons generating the substantial box office receipts in the top ten films accounts for the substantial increases in visitors to movies' film locations. While the *Lord of the Rings* and *Harry Potter* movies have shown to be global major box office successes, the same can also be said for New Zealand and United Kingdom tourist visitor numbers who seek Middle Earth and the home of the wizards. Visitor numbers to both of these destinations has increased exponentially with each movie instalment release. *Lord of the Rings* has provided New Zealand with a new level of global recognition, as well as a facilitator for growth (Voight, 2005). Regarding the impacts of New Zealand films on tourism, it has been found that tourists visit remote locations in order to re-enact scenes from the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy. Furthermore, repeat tourism has increased to these locations, with movie tourists visiting *Lord of the Ring* film locations as many as three times, and that Middle Earth had become 'more real' as they were now able to first hand experience

the sights, sounds and sensations of the movie (Buchmann, 2004).

As a result of the fantasy world written by J.R.R. Tolkien and delivered by Peter Jackson, visitors to New Zealand can now book movie site tours with operators that have been specifically established, buy a road tour map dedicated to following the journey from the comfort of a car or motor home to Middle Earth, or take to the air to see the Plains of Rohan and the Woods of Lothlorien (Wigney, 2006). Outlining over 150 sites used for the trilogy, the *Lord of the Rings* guidebook had by 2003, sold more than 96,000 copies in New Zealand and Australia (Arpe, 2003). This popularity of visiting New Zealand is highlighted by one in ten visitors declaring that they are attracted as a result of the trilogy (Lilley, 2004), with an annual international tourism growth of nine percent (Tourism Research Council of New Zealand, 2005) since the first *Lord of the Rings* movie release in 2001. This reinforces the notions of organically evolved and associative cultural landscapes created by the trilogies and layered upon the New Zealand landscape. Furthermore, a new form of place-identity has arisen, the one of Middle Earth with conceptual and physical boundaries, in which visitors share patterns of meanings with each other regarding social identity.

According to National Statistics (2002), tourism to the United Kingdom in 2001 had decreased 0.6%. However, since the 2001 release of the first *Harry Potter* movie, there has been a substantial increase in international

TABLE 1. All Time Highest Grossing Movies Worldwide

	Released	Film Name	Total Box Office US\$
1	1997	Titanic	\$1,835,400,000
2	2003	Lord of the Rings: The Return of the King	\$1,129,027,325
3	2001	Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone	\$974,557,891
4	1999	Star Wars: Phantom Menace	\$925,600,000
5	2002	Lord of the Rings: The Two Towers	\$924,291,552
6	1993	Jurassic Park	\$920,100,000
7	2004	Shrek 2	\$916,121,703
8	2005	Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire	\$892,213,036
9	2002	Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets	\$878,987,880
10	2001	Lord of the Rings: The Fellowship of the Ring	\$864,614,978

Adapted from *The Numbers* (2006, p. 1).

and domestic tourist visits throughout the United Kingdom. Tourist visits to *Harry Potter* movie locations have increased since the first movie release, with most movie locations experiencing an increase of 50% in visitor numbers (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). The Grand Cathedral in Gloucester—Hogwarts School—in 2001 had visitor numbers of 288,906; 90,000 more than in 2000 (BBC News, 2002). The city of Oxford has also experienced the positive side of movie tourism, with an increase of 60% of tourism visits to the sites of Bodleian Library—Hogwarts Library; and the Dining Hall located at Oxford University (Oxford Inspires, 2005). Alnwick Castle in Northumberland, Hogwart's broomstick flying lessons, noted an increase in tourist figures from 52,000 in 2000 to over 300,000 visitors in the 2003 tourist season (Brooks, 2003).

The United Kingdom is benefiting from increased domestic tourism with one in six tourists now visiting at least one film location utilised in the movies (Martin, 2004), whereas VisitBritain (2006) estimates around one in five of Britain's international visitors are inspired to visit the United Kingdom by the images they see in movies or on television. It is envisaged that the promotion of the *Harry Potter* sites will increase visits to Britain and raise the value of the £74 billion visitor economy (VisitBritain, 2006). It could therefore be perceived that these locations have become an associative cultural landscape. It could also be alleged that those visiting are either eager Muggles or fledging wizards desiring to belong to the wizard community, identifying and journeying to these places of attachment. Although a social construct, as earlier noted, a person's sense of identity is frequently connected to land (Mazlish, 1993; Clayton & Opatow, 2003) and movie locations are the prime tool in helping people to connect and create place-identity.

It is interesting to note that in Table 1; only one movie is based on an historic occurrence—*Titanic*. This movie can be related to the aspect of imagined nostalgia and a yearning for the romance of a bygone

era. An insight into the past but one that that is of a new reality of what occurred on the *Titanic* based on a combination of fact and imagination. A new myth arises of a love story between a wealthy and poor individual whose romance was physically destroyed on the night of the sinking but not emotionally. The remaining top ten movies are of imagined worlds and realities. Of these, one is animated and therefore is understood by the movie going public to be purely a story. The others, it can be argued, could be 'real'. *Jurassic Park* is of an actual location, filmed in Kaua'i Hawaii, and although utilised for other movies such as *Godzilla*, *50 First Dates*, *Mighty Joe Young*, *Windtalkers*, *Tears of the Sun*, *Pearl Harbour* and the television series, *Fantasy Island* (Fischer, 2006), it is presently the location of the TV series *Lost*. Although there are a number of theories about the island (Lost Theory Generator, 2006), there has been a suggestion that the mysterious creature is in actual fact one of the escaped *Jurassic Park* creatures. Thus, a new associative cultural landscape is created, from whichever theory fans of the show desire.

The movie franchises of *Harry Potter*, *Star Wars*, and *Lord of the Rings* reinforce the notion of a new cultural landscape for the locations where they were filmed. As earlier notated, the locations of these movies influence individuals to travel (Riley, Baker & van Doren, 1998; Jones, 2002). These movies are about alternative worlds and realities and their locations have become social constructions in the minds of the individual. A new reality based on tangible remains, strengthening Herbert's (2001) assessment that visitors are not concerned with the distinction between reality and fiction but rather the features that involve imagination and awareness. A direct comparison to UNESCO's (1997) definition of associative cultural landscape and in the case of the tourism industry earnings, an organically evolved landscape created for economic purposes. Movies have created social identities and connection for people in the form of community with other like-minded

individuals, fulfilling the need to belong as a collective group (Lerner, 1985). In turn, place-identities to the physical locations of the movies are formed by a construction of ideas, interpretation and feelings (Dixon & Durrheim, 2000; Holmes, 2003), creating a sense of belonging and sense of self. Although this can be argued against, it is interesting that these three franchises form seven of the top ten top grossing movies, movies involving fantasy, action, adventure, alternate worlds, good fighting evil, and magic. Perhaps these new cultural landscapes being created from the movie industry with a flow-on affect on the tourism industry are the desire to escape everyday life and reality, constructing for the individual new identities and realities.

CONCLUSION

The tourism industry is constantly creating new forms of markets, one being Movie Tourism. There has been a growing worldwide phenomenon that tourists are now visiting a destination or attraction as a result of being featured in the popular cultural forms of the media such as movies, while not being directly involved in the tourism marketing of the destination (Morgan & Pritchard, 1998; Jones, 2002). The images the movie goer forms as a result of watching a movie provides responses of the location as a 'must see' destination. Box office receipts are reflective in the popularity of the cinema experience, which is also reflective in the visitor number increases of two franchises of the world's most popular movies of all time (National Statistics, 2005; Tourism Research Council of New Zealand, 2005). Yet, this can be seen as a clinical approach in terms of statistics. Movies create new cultural landscapes, an interaction between and evolution of society's external and internal economic, cultural and social aspects as per UNESCO's (1997) definition. Movie Tourism becomes an additional layer to the ongoing and evolving changes within cultural landscapes and the social constructions and perceptions

of society. As has been proposed, the locations in a movie are not only the incentive for an individual to travel but rather can form part of individual identity and place-identity. This desire, created from movies, creates a shared pattern of meanings with others, a new community to belong to and operate in.

This connection to place-identity and with it, new forms of cultural landscape, started to occur before the advent of global successful movies. Literary places as described in novels connected emotionally and compelled people to visit (Squire, 1996; Herbert, 2001). Movies have increased this compulsion as a greater awareness is now created to a global audience. The increased visitation numbers to a country of where a successful movie was filmed has also increased the number of tourism operators offering specific tours and packages (Beeton, 2001a, 2001b; Heath, 2005) to those seeking the new cultural landscapes. Movies engage the audience, constructing new realities and truths. It is these new realities, set in physical locations that can be visited, that create a new form of cultural landscape and dependent upon the movie, can be divided into one of three UNESCO's (1997) cultural landscape categories: the clearly defined; the organically evolved; and the associative cultural.

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